struck by the frequent mentions, brief and undeveloped as they usually are, of painting and the arts in community activities.[9]

Can one even go so far as to suggest that, given the number and productivity of Asian American artists, the special place accorded art by many people of Asian descent, and the connections of these artists with the general American art world (unacknowledged as they have been), the visual arts are an especially rich site for study of Asian American experiences? As a site of cultural and social expression, might visual art even be considered for Asian Americans akin in importance to the central place that music occupies in the African American experience? Might it be that Asian Americans have made special and unique contributions to the visual arts?

A number of other areas of study of Asian American life may benefit from a greater appreciation of the visual arts:

THE ARTWORK AND CAREERS of the artists themselves offer fresh material to enlarge our understanding of Asian American social and intellectual history. If we understand this art as social as well as personal expression, it can help us gain insights into a wide variety of subjects, such as identity formation and projection, felt experience, perceptions of racial and ethnic identity and place, the texture of daily life, and intellectual and personal interaction with other communities, both white and minority.

ART HISTORY CAN LEAD to greater understanding of the internal organizational and institutional dynamics of Asian American communities, especially art clubs and societies, festivals, and even commerce (the ubiquitous art and curio stores, and galleries) and the business of art.

ART, IN ITS MANY FORMS, often played an important role in the daily lives of Asian Americans. Art, for many, was not something distant or only for the "privileged" but was an important and integral element in the home, family, and community. This recognition helps us begin to recover a sense of the actual lived experience of Asian American lives.

ART MAY LEAD US to better understand the forms of political expression. Some artists were thoroughly apolitical and detached from social activism, but a great many of the artists mentioned in this volume were profoundly affected by contemporary social movements and participated as artist activists. Asian American artists such as Yasuo Kuniyoshi and Yun Gee strongly opposed Japanese aggression in Asia during the 1930s and 1940s. Eitaro Ishigaki and Isamu Noguchi used their art to protest American racism. In the 1960s and 1970s, Lewis Suzuki, Nanying Stella Wong, Mitsu Yashima, and, of course, many younger Asian American artists used their creative talents to oppose the Vietnam War.

ASIAN AMERICAN ART OFFERS the exciting possibility of viewing the *familiar*, such as places, people, and life experiences, in *unfamiliar* ways, of seeing America with "new eyes." Chiura Obata's *Setting Sun: Sacramento Valley* (see Mark Johnson's essay, fig. 10) and Chang Dai-chien's vision of Yosemite, *Autumn Mountains in Twilight* (see page xiv), offer fresh perspectives on the American landscape. We might gain new ways of understanding how others in the past have viewed traditional themes such as the "West," man and nature, the city, and, of course, race. Asian American art also might reveal the *unfamiliar* (at least for many other Americans), such as the internment experience or the attachment to heritage prompted by exile and social alienation.

THIS ARTWORK ALSO ENCOURAGES us to think about the many ways that cultural influences from Asia have influenced America. T'eng K'uei (Teng Baiye) came from China in 1924, studied art at the University of Washington in Seattle, did graduate work at



Portrait of T'eng K'uei with dedication to Mark Tobey, 1926. Courtesy University of Washington Libraries, Special Collections, UW 23723z. © Mark Tobey Estate/Seattle Art Museum.

Harvard University, then returned to China in 1931. While living in the Seattle area, he became friends with Mark Tobey and gave Tobey early lessons in Chinese brushwork. One of the great influences on Tobey's own work was a trip to China and Japan in 1934, during which time he visited T'eng K'uei in Shanghai and attended lectures and classes with his friend. How have artists such as T'eng K'uei been creative agents of this influence? How did they actively explore aesthetic interaction? In what ways have Asian American artists themselves been cultural translators, transmitters, or interpreters?



Chang Dai-chien, *Autumn Mountains in Twilight*, 1967. Mineral pigments and ink on paper, 75⅝ × 40¾ in. Courtesy Mei Yun Tang Collection.

THE WAYS THAT DOMINANT SOCIETY received and understood Asian American artists may lead to new ways of understanding the dynamics of race and racial ideologies in America.

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ALL IN ALL, REGARDLESS OF whatever importance Asian American art may have for the future understanding of history, these newfound artifacts from the past, these wonderful creative expressions, can now be enjoyed once again as their creators had intended: as works of emotion, of beauty, of protest, of intellectual engagement, or deeply personal sentiment. These works of art can speak to us across the divide of time. There is no Asian American aesthetic to which a work must adhere to be appreciated.[10] Exactly how we will view these works will depend on how receptive we are to challenges to our assumptions about "American art," "modern art," "Asian art," and even about Asian Americans themselves.